“Mission in the Kingdom of Snows” (Despara Au)

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/75381026.

Rating:
General Audiences

Archive Warnings:
Creator Chose Not To Use Archive Warnings, Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Categories:
F/F, Other

Fandoms:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), Despara - Fandom

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Despara - Character, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Lonnie (She-Ra), Kyle (She-Ra), Rogelio (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Perfuma (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Hordak (She-Ra), Entrapta (She-Ra), Frosta (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Despara AU, Alternate Universe, Evil Adora (She-Ra), Catra is Bad at Feelings (She-Ra), Manipulative Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra), Horde Lord Adora (She-Ra), ilikeyoucatradora

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by Aladiah

Summary

Despara has already secured the Runestones of Plumeria and Salineas, and her next target is the Kingdom of Snow. Catra, accompanied by her squad and Scorpia, is ordered to infiltrate the Princess Ball and steal the stone without leaving a trace.

The mission seems straightforward… until a princess who’s a little too bright and a little too curious turns the whole plan into a frozen labyrinth of complications.

This short story is part of the Despara AU by ilikeyoucatradora.

Notes

Notes:
In this new Despara story, the events take place shortly after the events of this mini comic:
https://www.instagram.com/p/CNS5yi0gJ6X/?igsh=amE1YjVmN21wczNp

We’re not really used to writing fanfics — this started as a small project because we wanted Despara to have a bit more content out there. It was meant to be just a short story with some illustrations, and in the end we decided to share it here on AO3.

English is not our first language, so there might be some narrative or grammatical mistakes here and there. Still, we hope the story reads clearly enough.

If you want to understand the whole context of this Despara AU, most of the information and artwork is on our Instagram. This fic is just another piece of that universe.

Hope you enjoy this little story.

Chapter 1: The Mission



A tense silence engulfed the throne room as Catra came face to face with Adora, who now had a preference of calling herself "Despara." It had been a considerable amount of time since their last conversation, but even though the cut on her face had completely healed, the emotional wound, far from closing,

seemed to be reopening more and more with each passing day. Despite this, as they say, curiosity killed the cat, and Catra couldn't help but be intrigued about the purpose of this unusual summons, so she had decided to set aside her resentment and attend the meeting.

"You called me, Ado... I mean, Commander Despara?" Catra asked, unable to hide a certain bitterness in her tone. Despara turned towards her, holding an elegant scroll in her hands, which seemed to contain something of great importance.
Though she didn't look directly at Catra, she finally spoke, "Yes, I have a task for you. It will be a tricky mission."

Catra's heart began to beat faster, a mix of uncertainty and intrigue.
"What is it about?" she asked, unable to conceal her curiosity.
Despara extended the scroll towards her with an intriguing demeanaur. It was an invitation to the Princess Prom in the Kingdom of Snows an event that took place every ten years and to which all the princesses of Etheria had been invited.
Catra furrowed her brow, confused, as she read the contents of the scroll. "It's an invitation for... Scorpia? Scorpia is a princess?"



Despara let out a mocking laugh that echoed through the walls of the room. "Of course she is. The Horde invaded her family's kingdom years ago, and they handed over the Black Garnet to Hordak. They explained it during Force Captain training... You should know," she laughed.

Catra futilely tried to hide her surprise and embarrassment by looking away. "I guess I missed that lesson," she muttered. "If

this is an invitation for Scorpia, what do I have to do with it?"

Despara stared at her intently, with a malicious smile that sent shivers down Catra's spine. "You will go to the prom with Scorpia as her plus one. You know how I desire to conquer that kingdom, don't you?" Catra was stunned. The magnitude of the mission began to weigh on her shoulders.

"And of course, steal their Runestone..." she whispered, understanding Despara's objective.
Party time.

Chapter 2: Princess Prom

Scorpia's unease grew as she tried to balance mentally reviewing the plan with keeping an ounce of grace walking in that tight black dress. All the while, she scrutinized her surroundings with distrust, as if anticipating an imminent attack, and voiced all her concerns aloud.

"We'll be crushed as soon as they see us! The princesses have never shown sympathy for my family, and now, with everything that's happening..."

Catra, who appeared imposing in Scorpia's eyes - lacking a word that truly defined what she felt when seeing her in an elegant burgundy suit and jacket - , exhaled with apparent boredom as she looked around.

"Just make sure you play your part of the plan and keep your mouth shut," she whispered patiently as they walked across the ice bridge leading to the majestic ice palace.



Upon reaching the entrance, they were surprised to find more people than they had expected. The kingdoms of Plumeria and Salineas had fallen to the Horde's most recent attack, losing their precious Runestones due to Despara's actions. The princesses and inhabitants had been forced to seek refuge in other kingdoms, yet judging by the number of people crowding the entrance, no one wanted to miss the party.

For Catra and Scorpia, two dangerous members of the Horde, infiltrating this gathering of resentful princesses posed a significant risk. What if Scorpia was right and it was a trap? But even if they were captured, or worse, killed on the mission, it wouldn't provide a strategic advantage for the Rebellion either. Despara no longer cared about anything or anyone, and the loss of a couple of soldiers wouldn't stop her, Catra thought bitterly.

Nevertheless, Catra still wondered why Scorpia had received an invitation to such a significant event in Etheria during these gloomy times. Perhaps it was a mere formality, and they anticipated she would decline the invitation? Or maybe the princesses held hope for a temporary truce, if only for tonight? Catra had to force herself to stop these intrusive thoughts if she wanted to focus on the mission.

"Do you think Lonnie and Kyle are in position? We haven't received their signal in a while..." Scorpia asked, tapping the hidden communicator in her ear.

Lonnie and Kyle played a crucial role in replacing the castle's royal sentinels, thus avoiding weapons inspection (the Rebellion might be stupidly naive sometimes, but not naive enough to keep letting anyone into their realms without prior registration). Meanwhile, Rogelio waited in a hidden skiff behind the glaciers, ready to provide support from the outside.

Almost as if they had tuned into their thoughts, a voice emerged from Catra's discreet earpiece. "Catra, you can proceed now. Kyle

and I are in the security control area. Moving on to phase two," Lonnie's voice resonated through the communicator.

A wave of relief washed over Catra upon receiving this confirmation. Knowing that Lonnie and Kyle were in position indicated that the operation was underway, getting closer to its objective.

Catra and Scorpia headed toward where Lonnie and Kyle were waiting, dressed in their respective disguises. Catra could barely contain a laugh as she saw them, comically bulky in their fur coats. Catching Catra's amused gaze, Lonnie grumbled irritably as she superficially scanned them with a deactivated weapons detector, while Kyle did the same with Scorpia.

"You took your time," Catra joked. "Let me guess, Kyle used the stun baton on himself again."

Lonnie snorted loudly, confirming Catra's suspicions. She glanced sideways at Kyle, who was moving oddly, as if his legs had a mind of their own, a side effect of the baton’s electrical attack.

"I had to revive him. Don't ask," Lonnie spat through clenched teeth, while Kyle shrank under his oversized coat. Catra stifled a chuckle and made a gagging gesture. With the registration process complete, they were granted access to the palace.



"Good luck!" Kyle said, trying to offer support despite his trembling. It wasn't clear whether it was the result of the electricity, the cold atmosphere, fear, or all of the above.

"Stars, I don't know how that guy has survived this long," Scorpia marveled as they entered through the grand ice door.

Chapter 3: Glitter

The radiant beauty of the colossal ice hall, the stream of laughter, dances, and joy from the inhabitants of the diverse kingdoms of Etheria managed to overshadow the concerns of the ongoing war. Even the presence of the newcomers seemed to go unnoticed amid the festive bustle.

Catra clung firmly to Scorpia's spiky arm, gracefully leading her through the expansive ice staircase while absorbing every detail of the surroundings with interest. The music, a luxury she hadn't had many chances to enjoy during her life in the Horde, resonated in the air, and the culinary offerings surpassed Catra's most audacious smuggling experiences. If the rebellion had tanks the size of those cakes, they would have surely won the war by now.

Scorpia, absorbed in the fascination of the surroundings, appeared much more relaxed. Both turned their gaze to the Prom’s hostess, Princess Frosta, all regal on her icy throne. Despite her apparent youth, (she looked no more than 9 or 10 in Catra’s opinion), her presence exuded an authority difficult to ignore.

Before they could perform the customary bow to Frosta, a sparkly and pinkish beam unexpectedly emerged in front of Catra and Scorpia, startling them. Catra instantly recognized which princess this visiting card belonged to and wasn't particularly thrilled to be interrupted by her. The princess in question also didn't seem too pleased to see her.

"Hey, Sparkles..." Catra greeted with exaggerated joy.

"YOU... how dare you show up here, Horde scum?" Glimmer exclaimed, overflowing with glitter-infused fury.

In the midst of this sudden conflict, Princess Frosta, visibly surprised and annoyed, raised an eyebrow in curiosity, seeking to understand the cause of the confrontation.

"Esteemed hostess, they are from the Horde," Glimmer proclaimed with a grating voice, disdainfully pointing at the pair.

"Princess Scorpia was invited under the Princess Prom's rules," Catra asserted with calculated swiftness, her voice carrying a hint of innocence. "Rules that I deeply respect," she added, concluding with a smirking smile directed at the sparkly princess.

Catra's words prompted an immediate reaction from Glimmer, whose teeth clenched with contained fury. An almost inaudible whisper escaped her lips: "Liar."

Nevertheless, Catra and Scorpia, unperturbed, waited calmlyfor a response from the hostess, intensifying Glimmer's anger.



Frosta, to Glimmer's surprise, declared with an authoritative voice that contrasted with her innocent looks, "The rules state that all princesses are welcome. This celebration has always been neutral, and I won't dishonor that legacy."

"You know the Horde has invaded the realms of Salineas and Plumeria, stealing the magic from their Runestones! They're here because they're planning something! I'm sure of it!" Glimmer exclaimed, revealing palpable fear in her words.

Frosta seemed to hesitate at this information and pressed her lips, contemplating what to say, casting a distrustful glance towards Catra.

Noticing Frosta's change of attitude, Catra hastened to say, "You can rest assured, Sparkles... Despara isn't here, and we aren't breaking any rules... Didn't you read the invitation?" She then shot an offended look at Frosta and made an exaggerated curtsy while saying, "It's evident that Scorpia'sinvitation was a mistake." She then turned to Scorpia, who also bowed silently. Catra looked at her with sadness, sighing loudly. "You were right about the princesses, Scorpia. They invited you to save face because they didn't expect you to show up. We better leave... what the Princess Prom represents is a farce."

Just as they prepared to descend the staircase, Frosta's voice stopped them, and Catra had to suppress a satisfied smile.

"Wait!"

Frosta stood up and, with a softer tone, said, "I apologize; I know the circumstances haven't been the best. Please, stay; this is a ceremony of unity, and everyone deserves to enjoy it."

Catra, still on guard, exchanged a look with Scorpia.

"I assure you we will do our best to make the rest of the evening go smoothly," Frosta insisted, her tone revealing a genuine intention to maintain peace. Glimmer, visibly displeased, let out a grunt of disbelief, but Frosta gave her a firm look before she could protest.

Scorpia, with an expression oscillating between uncertainty and anticipation, waited for Catra's response. The latter remained silent for a moment, assessing the situation. Finally, with a gesture of resignation, she nodded slightly, agreeing to Frosta's offer.

Acknowledging her defeat, Glimmer frowned in disapproval.Knowing that insisting would be useless and would only put Brightmoon in a bad light, she settled for ensuring the couple didn't attempt anything during the event on her own.

With determined steps, she sought Bow in the crowd, hoping he had witnessed the scene from afar to spare her explanations. However, like the others, he seemed immersed in the carefree joy of the Princess Prom, oblivious to the tension that unfolded on the main stage.

Bow had chosen to bring Princess Perfuma as his companion. The Flower Princess was known for her affable and serene nature, but lately she had been withered and affected by sadness for days due to what happened in her kingdom and with her Runestone. Bow, always the kind one, had the idea of taking Perfuma out of

the walls of Brightmoon so she could relax a bit amid the festivities. It was clear Glimmer wouldn't be able to count on him tonight.

Amidst the celebration, she felt alone, as if the laughter and dances of the attendees were an insurmountable wall given the weight on her shoulders. After waiting for this event for so long, it was turning into one of the worst days of her life. At least, by focusing on thwarting the Horde's plans, she wouldn't have to think about it.

Emptying her lungs in a sigh, she resigned herself to act as if nothing was happening and made her way through the lively conversation, reaching the group where Bow, Perfuma, Sea Hawk, and other princesses she didn't know were sharing stories.

As usual, the extravagant pirate was talking about his "beloved" Mermista, lamenting her absence. The marine princess couldn't attend the ball as she was busy recruiting pirates, mercenaries, and anyone with a sword and a penchant for a fight in Seaworthy in an attempt to reclaim her kingdom invaded by the Horde. Glimmer suspected that Mermista had insisted on Sea Hawk attending the event without her to keep him away. Sea Hawk could be very irritating, and Mermistawasn't in the best mental state to tolerate him for long.

Bow, noticing Glimmer's serious look, approached with concern and asked, "Glimmer, you disappeared a while ago! Where were you?" Glimmer returned the look, noticing that Perfuma was watching her with a gentle smile while holding onto Bow's arm. Trying to project confidence in the face of the audacity of the flower princess, she put on her best smile and practically yelled, "I

just needed to take a walk and enjoy the party from a different perspective. I'm having so much fun, making new friends, and exploring what the Princess Prom has to offer. I'm really enjoying tonight!!" Then she let out a loud chuckle that puzzled Bow, while Perfuma, Sea Hawk, and the others looked at her with bewilderment.



Um...". Noticing the confused looks, Glimmer hurriedly changed the subject. "Oh!! I was trying the culinary delights. Have you tried the...?" she said, looking towards the cake tables.

At that moment, Glimmer caught the resonant voice of Scorpia attacking the pastries with enthusiasm at one of the tables, and noticed with horror that someone was missing. Desperately, she searched for the elusive feline until she located her, stealthily sliding towards Princess Entrapta, up on one of the balconies.

The princess with purple pigtails seemed immersed in a conversation with her recorder, oblivious to the imminent danger that Catra represented, and too close to the edge of the balustrade that separated her from a deadly fall.

Before Bow had the chance to approach and ask Glimmer what was happening, she stifled a shriek and disappeared in a flash of light, reappearing right where Catra and Entraptawere.

Chapter 4: The Trap

Glimmer, oscillating between suspicion and disdain, fixed her gaze on Catra. The princess's eyes sparkled with distrust towards the feline.

"You were right!! This viewpoint is much better," intervened Entrapta enthusiastically, breaking the tension in the air. "Oh, hi! Um... You were...?" she asked, addressing Glimmer.

Catra, with a mocking smile, stepped forward with a sarcastic comment, "She's my shadow, 'Sparkles.' Seems like she wants to join us for a little spying, isn't that adorable?"

Glimmer interrupted with a shrill voice, "Entrapta, don't get close to her, she's from the Horde!" Confusion reflected on Entrapta's face, unable to grasp the urgency in Glimmer's words.

"The Horde, Entrapta! They're the enemy we're fighting against!" Glimmer replied, frustrated, waving her arms as if that would help Entrapta understand the nuances of what she was implying. From the scientist's expression, she wasn’t succeeding. "The rebellion you're a part of!"

Entrapta smiled compassionately, to which Glimmer responded with a defeated growl.

"Why are you worried about who Entrapta associates with?" Catra interjected, sliding an arm over Entrapta's shoulders. "No one besides me has shown interest in her technological knowledge. Except for using it to their advantage, right, Entrapta?"

Glimmer could see how Catra's words were impacting Entrapta, slightly dimming the sparkle in her eyes. With a mix of fury and disbelief, she pulled at the tech girl’s arm, who let out a surprised yelp. "Don't even try, Horde scum!"

Entrapta seemed uncomfortable, her gaze shifting from one to the other without knowing what to say. "Actually, the strange cat lady has a point. I can't do anything useful in the rebellion; they won't let me progress. But in the Horde, she says maybeI..." she confessed, in a barely audible murmur.

Glimmer couldn't believe what she was hearing. Desperate to change Entrapta's perspective, Glimmer tried to convince her of her worth in the rebellion, but her words seemed hollow against Catra's cunning. Catra, with apparent gravity, tilted her head towards Glimmer's lack of argument. "You have Entrapta because you got there first, seducing her with false promises. But in the Horde, she could be someone important. She'd have her own lab, could manipulate First Ones' technology, and even experiment with runestones," she whispered, weaving a web of temptations around the engineer princess whose eyes began to gleam with excitement.

With a frustrated sigh, Glimmer burst out, "Entrapta, you need to open your eyes! The Horde isn't what it seems. They're not friendly inventors; they're invaders and plunderers!"

"But... Catra told me in the Horde I could have the chance to continue my experiments without restrictions. Imagine the number of secrets I could uncover about Etheria! The amazing things I could do with their technology," she responded with a shrill voice, sounding madly excited.

Catra leaned on the railing, watching the conflict she had created with a mocking smile on her lips.


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"But, Entrapta, do you really think the Horde will let you do as you please?" Glimmer continued. "They're using you, just like they do with the runestones. You'll be nothing more than a pawn in their game!"

Visibly uncomfortable and wishing to end the lecture, Entrapta simply decided to leave to continue her social experiments.

"Entrapta! Wait! You don't know the possible ramifications of involving with them!" Glimmer yelled, trying to follow her.

"I do! That's what makes it fun!" exclaimed Entrapta as she ran even faster, leaving Glimmer behind.

Glimmer let out a resigned sigh, aware that she would have to deal with Entrapta another time. Her priority now was to keep a vigilant eye on the unpleasant Horde guests.

Turning to face Catra, she found an empty spot. Realizing the feline had disappeared without a trace, she sighed in a silent plea to the heavens for a little patience.

She leaned on the railing and desperately searched for Bow. The music had shifted to a softer ballad, and she watched as the guests prepared to dance in each other's arms. Among the crowd, she spotted Perfuma's shiny blonde mane, seemingly alone and lost in the crowd.

Glimmer appeared in a flurry of sparks in front of Perfuma, startling her. "Have you seen Bow?" she asked urgently.

Perfuma frowned. "I was about to ask you the same thing! He went to get his sash a while ago when the Horde princess left."

"UGH!!! Scorpia dispeared too??" Glimmer growled with frustration as she scanned the area in all directions. Something was terribly wrong.

With her heart pounding, Glimmer pushed her way through the crowd in the ballroom, leaving a concerned Perfuma behind as she frantically searched for her friend. Amidst the flickers of light and elegant dances, her gaze swept from side to side, desperate to find Bow among the guests.

Finally, in the distance, she caught a familiar face: Catra disappearing behind a door in one of the corridors. Without hesitation, Glimmer rushed in her direction, ignoring the curious looks of those present as she stormed through the room like a whirlwind.

Upon reaching the hallway, her heart skipped a beat at the scene before her: two palace guards dragging Bow, his body limp in their arms. A cry of anguish escaped from Glimmer's lips, her voice echoing in the empty hallway as she rushed towards the scene, hoping to find her friend unharmed.

Filled with rage, Glimmer lunged at the fake guards holding Bow, her body enveloped in a glow of energy. Her fists struck with precision, driving back the impostors, and creating an opportunity to free her friend. However, Scorpia's sudden appearance added a new challenge to the fray.


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Scorpia's sharp tail became an additional threat, snaking quickly to attack Glimmer. With agile movements and sharp reflexes, the princess dodged the attacks, keeping her focus on the mission to rescue Bow.

Meanwhile, in the shadows, Catra watched the scene unfold. With princess sparkles occupied, it was the perfect time to act. With stealthy steps, she slipped towards the entrance of the Runestone chamber.

Chapter 5: The Runestone

In the icy shadows of the palace corridors, Catra stealthily made her way towards the Runestone room while Scorpia and the others kept the bothersome Sparkles occupied. She knew every second counted. As she approached, the light emanating from the magical stone seeped through the cracks of the ajar doors, drawing a trail of sparkles along her path.

For Catra, accustomed to the dark and monotonous Fright Zone, the sight of the Runestone seemed like something out of a dream. Floating in the center of the room, the gem radiated a hypnotic beauty, as dazzling as a star in the celestial sky. She had never seen the stars, but in her imagination, they must be a similar spectacle.

Clearing her mind of distractions, she stood before the imposing floating Rune, her heterochromatic eyes reflecting her determination. Using her skilled hands, she retrieved a small device from her jacket's inner pocket, a valuable gift from Adora, obtained through the mystical power of her sword. It looked like a small dagger, with an incredibly sharp and thin blade, almost like a needle.

It was time to fulfill her mission: break the magical link between the Runestone and Princess Frosta to facilitate the absorption of her power. The sharp weapon she held would be the vessel for that powerful ice magic.

This task was her golden opportunity to prove her worth, gain Hordak's recognition, and finally earn the approval she so longed for from Shadow Weaver. Adora had entrusted her with this important mission, which meant she would no longer have to live in anyone's shadow.

With the small dagger in her trembling hands, Catra couldn't help but feel a pang of sadness remembering Adora's drastic change. The girl who used to be her friend, her companion, now seemed to be on a completely different path, in a world apart from hers. The gap between them had grown so much that it sometimes felt like they were in separate universes.

Guilt resurfaced as she recalled the moment she betrayed Adora, revealing to Shadow Weaver what had happened in the forest with that cursed sword. Back then, fear dominated her; she feared Adora would leave the Horde to learn more about that new princess-y identity. She felt she had no other choice. She expected Shadow Weaver would just take the sword away, but what Catra hadn't anticipated was that the sorceress would use that newly acquired power to train Adora, taking her even further away from her. In her desperate attempt to keep her friend, she had contributed to her transformation and the growing chasm between them, a burden Catra constantly carried.


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With her heart racing, Catra pushed those thoughts aside and forced herself to focus on the task at hand. Despite the sadness that engulfed her when recalling the past, she knew she had to stay focused on the present. She closed her eyes for a moment, taking a deep breath to calm her nerves, and dropped her purple jacket to the ground. Now she felt lighter, ready to face whatever it took to complete her mission.

Leaping deftly from platform to platform, Catra confronted the challenging height and slippery ground. Despite the cold that chilled her, sweat beaded on her forehead and her heart pounded fiercely. The mission was clear in her mind: drive the fine needle into the massive stone with a precise and firm strike, following Shadow Weaver's teachings to the letter.

Glimmer's tumultuous entrance broke the tense silence of the room. Her flushed face and sweat-soaked appearance betrayed her exhaustion, indicating that her teleportation magic was at its limit. Scorpia followed closely, her stinger raised, an uncharacteristic expression of fury on her face. Between gasps, she lamented not having managed to stop the elusive princess.

"Stop!" Glimmer shouted desperately, extending her hands towards Catra as she caught her breath. "Please! Don't do it!"

Something inside Catra hesitated for a moment, the hand holding the needle trembled as if something within her was pulling that arm. Catra's gaze met Glimmer's, who looked at her pleadingly.

The dark storm of emotions within her intensified. Memories of her friendship with Adora —the moments of complicity, the laughter they shared, the promises made in the darkness of the Horde— surfaced with unexpected intensity.

Urgently, Scorpia blocked the massive doors behind her with her pincers, shouting agitatedly: “Hurry, Catra! The palace guards have alerted Frosta! Time is running out!”

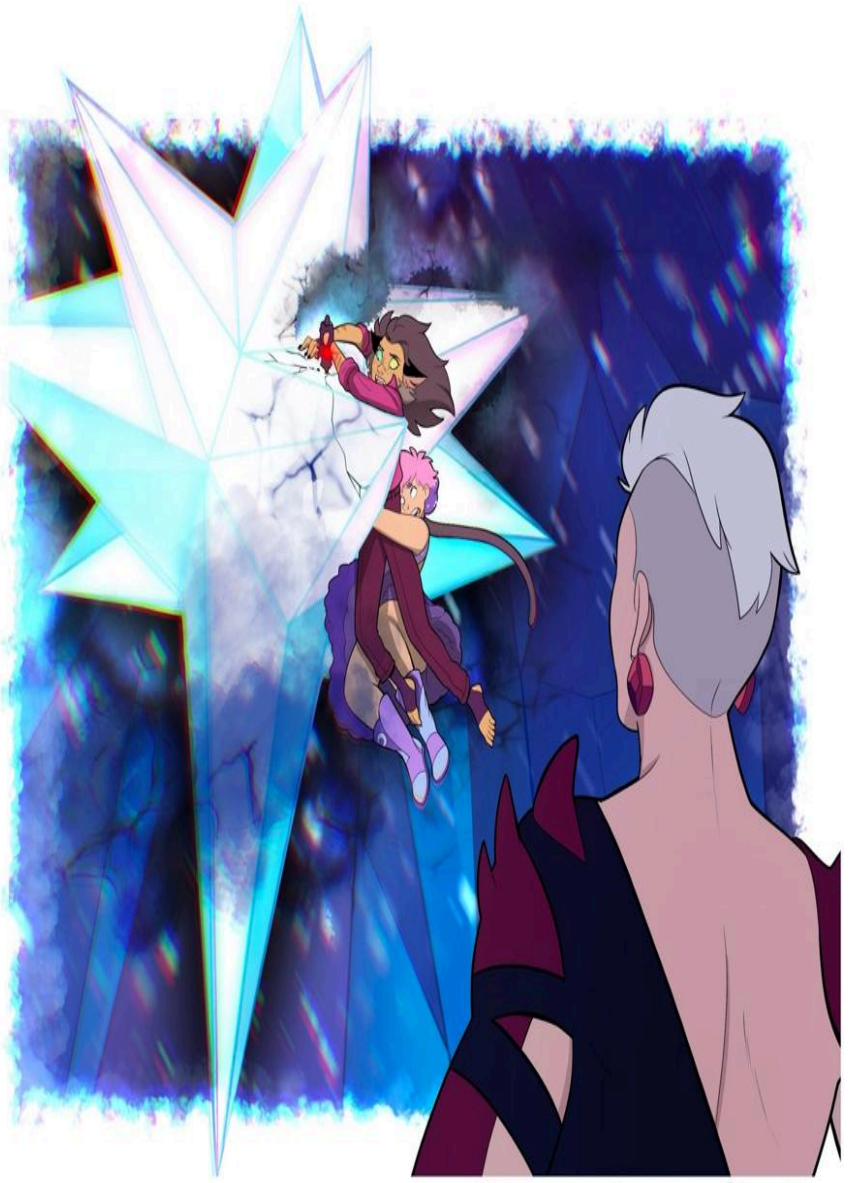
As Glimmer struggled to maintain her magic, Scorpia clung tightly to the enormous palace doors, desperately trying to prevent the guards from entering.

With a barely audible growl, Catra landed gracefully on one of the sharp peaks of the Runestone. Her posture radiated determination as she raised her arm decisively, ready to drive the needle with a precise strike.

Cursing under her breath and with a final effort, Glimmer materialized in a pink cloud and sparks right above Catra. Exhaustion caused her to lose precision, and she fell, clinging tightly to Catra’s waist. “Hey!” Catra exclaimed, surprised, as she slipped. To avoid falling into the void, Catra deftly clung to the dagger with both hands, driving it into the Runestone, which resonated and vibrated like a crystal about to shatter.

Catra clung tightly to the dagger, which began to emit a strange heat as the Runestone’s crystal started to crack. Her eyes widened in alarm. “Uh oh…” she murmured, realizing something was terribly wrong. Glimmer, still clinging to her waist, seemed on the

verge of fainting. “Catra, what have you done?” she whispered, barely audible, with a mix of surprise and concern in her voice.


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Scorpia watched the scene in horror, her heart pounding in her chest. The dagger Catra held began to emit a large, strange black cloud that moved and snaked around the two girls like a serpent of dark smoke. The cloud seemed alive, probing the air with sinister intent as the Runestone's glow darkened, pulsating with chaotic energy.

Catra, with sweat beading her forehead and muscles tense, stood on the brink of the abyss. Her hands trembled as she clung to the dagger, which now vibrated alarmingly. Every time she tried to stabilize herself, the black cloud pushed her closer to the edge, threatening to make her fall.

"This... isn't supposed to work... like this!" Catra shouted, her words filled with frustration and fear. Her body trembled under the effort of holding on, the tension in her arms almost unbearable.

Glimmer, still clinging to Catra's waist, fought to stay conscious. The magic within her was rapidly depleting, and the darkness of the black cloud seemed to suck away what little energy she had left. "Catra... we have to stop this," she murmured weakly, her voice barely audible among Catra's grunts of effort and the ominous hum of the Runestone.

But Catra was completely absorbed in her struggle, focused on her task of containing the Runestone's power within the dagger. She knew she couldn't afford to fail this mission. Adora and the

others had trusted her, she had to bring this contained magic back to the Horde or be willing to die trying.

Desperate, Scorpia took a step forward, her eyes filled with worry and fear. “Catra, let go! It will kill you!” she shouted, her voice filled with urgency and fear for her friend. But the black cloud extended further, forming tentacles that seemed to reach towards Scorpia, forcing her to retreat.

“Lonnie, Rogelio, we need help, now!” Scorpia shouted into her earpiece, her voice breaking. “Catra is in danger!”

With significant effort, Glimmer concentrated what was left of her power to teleport with Catra away from the Runestone before Catra could stop her. The sparks of magic flickered weakly around them as Glimmer struggled to stay conscious, her exhaustion evident. With a final flash, they disappeared in a pink cloud.

The two girls fell heavily, rolling on the ground as the sinister black cloud exploded in a burst of dark energy. Glimmer, exhausted, lost consciousness instantly; her magic was completely spent. The rumble echoed through the room, accompanied by sinister flashes that illuminated the unleashed chaos. With quick reflexes, Scorpia lunged towards them, catching them just in time before they were engulfed by the darkness.

Catra, dazed by the impact, looked up in horror at the dark cloud that was dispersing with a dreadful roar, but the chaos was not yet over. The Runestone roared with uncontrolled fury, unleashing a surge of frost and sharp ice spikes that began to invade the

room, tearing the walls apart as if they were paper. One of them cracked from top to bottom, and a huge gap opened, revealing the ruthless storm swirling outside.

The frost spread like sinister ivy towards them, enveloping the room in a deadly cold embrace. Scorpia pounced on Catra, who struggled and screamed:

"Scorpia, wait! We can't leave the dagger here!" Catra exclaimed, her voice resonating with urgency as she fought to free herself from Scorpia's grip.

"We don't have time for this, Catra! We're leaving now!" exclaimed Scorpia, her tone urgent as she dragged Catra toward the crack in the wall.

"We can't go back without it!" Catra screamed, anguished. The mere thought of facing Hordak and the others without having completed the mission paralyzed her with fear. The image of what could happen to them for having failed chilled her blood.

"I'm sorry, Catra, but there's no other choice! Let's go!" Scorpia responded with a mix of softness and firmness in her voice, reflecting her understanding of the situation. Determined, Scorpia took the lead towards the exit, dragging Catra with her as they escaped the growing calamity surrounding them.

The palace guards burst into the room, alarmed by the commotion. Princess Frosta led the group, her normally serene face now showing traces of contained fury as she extended her arms to contain the icy current emanating from the corrupted Runestone.

However, the snowstorm that had been unleashed seemed to defy even the princess's power. Despite her efforts, the magic had completely detached from the Runestone, acting independently and chaotically, as if it had a will of its own. Frosta frowned, feeling the cold penetrate her bones as her hands trembled from the icy wind. She scanned the hall for the culprits of this chaos, but only found Glimmer lying on the ground, unconscious. There was no sign of Catra or Scorpia. A furious tear rolled down her cheek as she accepted the harsh reality: her kingdom was in danger.

to be continued...

Chapter 6: Tool

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

The interior of Scorpia's ship was thick with tension, the silence weighing down like a gravestone. The air still carried the bitter scent of ozone and metal burned by ice, remnants of the catastrophic battle in the Runestone chamber.

The residual heat from takeoff was quickly dissipating, replaced by an unnatural cold seeping in from the outside—a chilling reminder of what they had unleashed. The very atmosphere seemed to have turned.

Catra remained in the cockpit, arms rigidly crossed over her chest, eyes fixed on an indeterminate point on the metallic wall. Her tail flicked through the air with frustration, an obvious reflection of the chaotic thoughts tangled in her mind.

Behind her, her squad waited in absolute silence.

Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio stood in their positions, tense, their gazes locked onto the floor or anywhere else that wasn't Catra. The weight of failure pressed down on all of them.

Scorpia piloted the ship, stiff, her pincers tightly closed. She seemed to be holding herself back, as if waiting for the exact moment when everything would explode.

No one spoke.

There was no need.

They had failed.

Catra closed her eyes, claws digging into her own arms. The echoes of the battle in the Runestone chamber still vibrated on

her skin: the cracking of the gemstone, the explosion of dark magic devouring the earth, and the snow covering Etheria in frozen vengeance. All because of her failure.

And, as if that weren't enough…

She had lost the dagger.

The dagger Despara had entrusted to her personally.

Adora—no, Despara—would never forgive this.

Her breathing grew heavy, uneven. She tried to steady herself, but the image of Despara looming over her with that cold, detached stare refused to leave her mind.

A metallic snap shattered the silence.

Catra’s eyes flew open.

Another sound. A dull thud.

And then, a voice.

"Oops! Was that important?"

From one of the ventilation grates above, purple cables tumbled to the floor with a metallic rattle. Seconds later, a figure descended with the nonchalance of someone stepping off a swing.

Entrapta.

She landed with a light bounce, straightening effortlessly and dusting herself off with a wide grin.

"Hi!" she greeted enthusiastically, as if she'd just arrived at a party. "Wow! This ship is incredible. But I have some improvement suggestions for the ventilation system. It’s a bit tight to move around, though I managed to optimize my mobility using my pigtails as—"

"HOW THE HELL DID YOU GET HERE?!" Catra roared, her tail bristling.

Entrapta blinked, tilting her head as if she didn’t understand the issue.

"Oh, well, I was exploring the ship and then suddenly—boom! The doors locked, the pilot shouted something about ‘evacuation mode,’ and we took off. And I thought: ‘Oh, wow! This is exciting!’"

Scorpia swallowed audibly. Kyle looked like he was about to collapse. Lonnie ran a hand down her face, muttering something unintelligible. Rogelio exhaled, visibly done with life.

Catra felt a buzzing in her head, the kind that came with mounting rage.

She closed her eyes and inhaled.

And then exhaled with a short, incredulous laugh—one filled with pure exhaustion.

"This can’t be happening." Her voice was barely a whisper as she ran her hands through her hair, yanking out a few strands in frustration. "This cannot be happening."

And yet, there stood Entrapta, right in the middle of the cockpit as if nothing were wrong, after sneaking onto a Horde ship without anyone noticing.

Then, a thought crossed Catra’s mind. She actually tried to convince Entrapta to join the Horde at the ball, and now she was there. Maybe not how she had planned, but she was there. Maybe the mission hadn’t been a total failure.

Oblivious to Catra’s epiphany, Entrapta kept talking.

"But don’t worry!" she said, waving her hands excitedly. "If you let me stay, I can make some improvements here. Did you know the

Horde’s navigation system has a slight delay in itsrotation calibration? You should be using a—"

The resounding crash of the ship’s doors opening cut her off.

Catra froze, but not because of the gust of icy air that cut straight into her bones.

Hordak. Shadow Weaver. Despara.

The three figures stood like statues of judgment on the landing strip, their silhouettes casting menacing shadows beneath the fortress’s red lights.

Catra felt the weight of defeat pressing down on her like a concrete slab.

This would be the worst homecoming of her life.

"Disembark."

Hordak’s voice echoed through the hangar with the finality of a verdict already rendered. He didn’t need details. He wasn’t asking for explanations. He had already made a decision.

Catra moved first, each step down the ramp heavier than the last, as if gravity itself was trying to drag her to the ground—to the condemnation that awaited her. Behind her, Lonnie, Kyle, and Rogelio followed in silence, their expressions hard, followed by Scorpia, ready to intervene if things spiraled out of control. As if that would make a difference.

And then, Entrapta, with her usual bright smile in place, as if she wasn’t standing in an enemy base. As if she wasn’t face-to-face with Hordak, Shadow Weaver, and Despara—the three most ruthless figures in the Horde.

"Wow, it’s really cold out here!" Entrapta commented casually, rubbing her arms. "Not a problem for me, but this place’s infrastructure might suffer if this temperature persists."

The Horde soldiers exchanged confused glances, some tightening their grips on their weapons, unsure if they should act or keep pretending this wasn’t happening.

Entrapta didn’t seem to notice the tension in the air—or if she did, she simply didn’t care. She turned toward Hordak, studying him with a mix of scientific fascination and uncontained excitement.

“Oh! Your armor is impressive!” she exclaimed, leaning forward without the slightest regard for personal space. “Is it a fusion of technology and biometal? Do you have an integrated exoskeleton, or is it part of your bone structure?”

Catra felt a nervous tic in her eye.

Shadow Weaver crossed her arms, her cloak floating slightly with restrained energy.

“Why is there a princess here?” Her mask tilted just enough to make her disdain all the more evident.

Catra felt her skin prickle.

Despara’s gaze slowly slid toward Catra with cold curiosity.

“I thought she could be useful to the Horde,” she replied quickly, choosing each word with precision. “The Rebellion recruited her recently. She’s an expert in technology and knows a lot about the Runestones.”

Entrapta nodded eagerly.

“Exactly!” she exclaimed, as if she were merely confirming a casual conversation. “This is so exciting. The Horde has an incredible infrastructure! I’ve been wanting to study it for a long time!”

Finally, Hordak spoke. "You three, take her to a cell. She’ll be interrogated later."

Lonnie nodded firmly, not questioning the order.

Rogelio growled in obedience, while Kyle seemed as if he wanted to say something but bit his tongue.

The three of them moved forward, grabbing Entrapta by the arms. She didn’t even try to resist.

"Oh, great!" she exclaimed with an enthusiasm that didn’t match the situation. "Can I see how the locks work from the inside? Do they use biometric codes or a combination of electromagnetic security systems? Oh, and we could optimize the interrogation system with artificial intelligence! Can I ask questions during the interrogation?"

The sound of the metal door closing behind Entrapta echoed in the hangar like a gunshot. A long, empty echo.

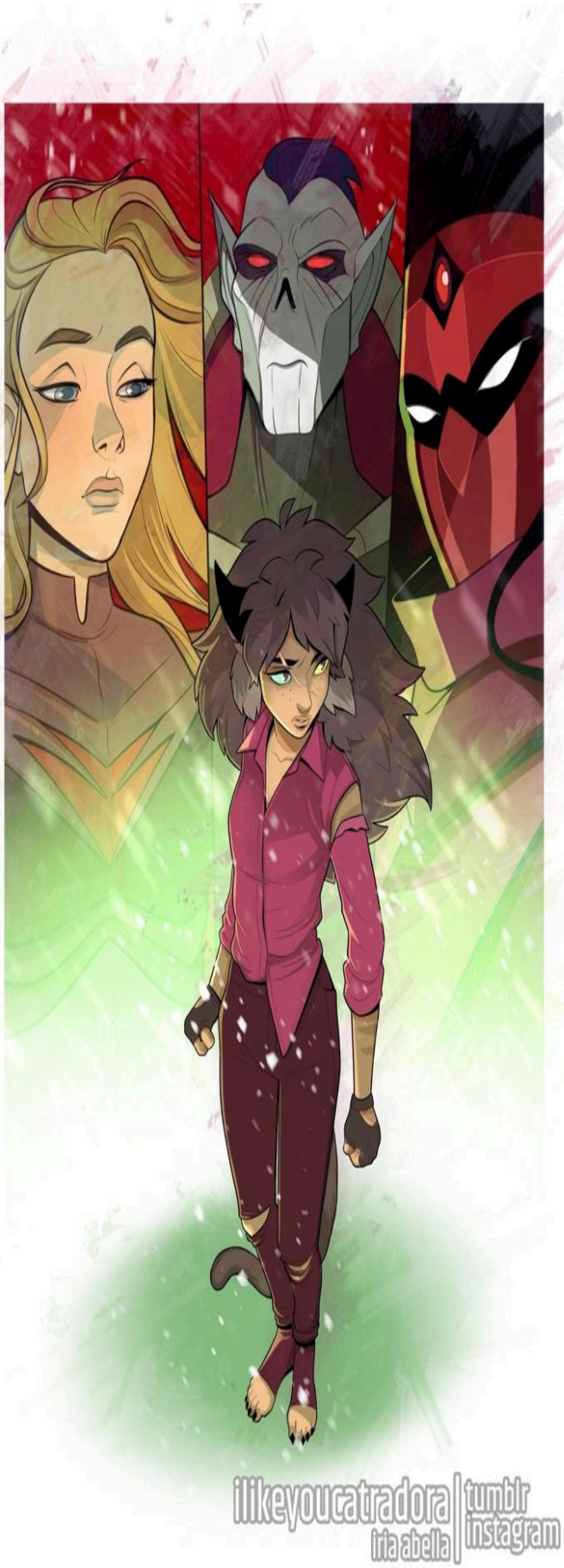
But the judgment wasn’t over.

Catra felt Hordak's gaze on her. Cold. Unyielding. Analytical.

Shadow Weaver advanced with the grace of a shadow, her cloak billowing with a faint glimmer of dark magic.

"What a predictable disaster," she said, her voice dripping with venom. "I should’ve known that trusting you with this mission would be a waste of resources."

Catra gritted her teeth, her claws digging into her palms.


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We did what we could," she said, her tone tight, controlled. But Shadow Weaver smiled with mockery.

"'What we could,' you say?" she repeated with disdain. "And what exactly did you accomplish?"

Shadow Weaver stepped closer to Catra, her mask tilting slightly.

"You didn't just fail to bring the power of the Runestone… you corrupted it." Her tone was like a shard of ice sliding beneath the skin. "You've thrown the planet into chaos."

Catra felt fury ignite in her chest like an uncontrollable fire, each of Shadow Weaver's words a wound, a calculated strike meant to humiliate her. But before she could react, a desperate voice shattered the silence.

"It was my fault!"

Scorpia.

"I... I should've stopped her!" she blurted out, turning to face Shadow Weaver, her eyes reflecting anguish. "That sparklyprincess... Glimmer... showed up at the worst possible moment. Right when the extraction was at its critical point."

Scorpia took a deep breath, trying to contain the frustration that overflowed with every word.

"I tried to stop her, I swear." Her pincers clenched tightly, her shoulders stiff. "But she was too fast. She teleported before I could even touch her. And then..."

Her voice faltered, her gaze dropping to the ground for a moment.

"Everything collapsed."

The air seemed to grow thicker.

"The magic got out of control," she continued, distress evident in her voice. "The Runestone fractured, the energy exploded, and everything turned to chaos. And Catra, she almost got killed!”

Catra felt a sharp, dry pain in her chest.

No. She couldn’t let Scorpia turn her into a victim.

“Shut up.”

Scorpia blinked, the weight of her own guilt reflected in her gaze, but she said nothing more.

Shadow Weaver let out a dry laugh.

“Almost got killed?” she murmured, with a trace of mockery in every syllable. “Maybe that would’ve been for the best.”

Catra could feel the fire inside her growing, uncontrollable.

“Enough.” Hordak’s voice cut through the air. “We lost the Runestone. What we’ve gained in return is uncertain.” Hordakcontinued, his gaze sweeping over the others. His tone remained impassive, but there was the clear hint of an underlying threat. “A new element has imposed itself over Etheria. A power we didn’t plan for, one we didn’t direct…”

Control, that was what concerned him.Not the failure, not the corruption of the Runestone, but that something had escaped his grasp.

Despara, who had remained silent until now, stepped forward.

“Perhaps not all is lost.”

Shadow Weaver narrowed her eyes.

Hordak watched her with renewed interest.

“This sudden winter…” Despara continued, her voice free of doubt, “could be an advantage.”

The others watched her in silence.

“The Rebellion wasn’t prepared for this,” she went on, her calm demeanor suggesting she’d already analyzed the situation. “Their lands, their refuges, their strategies… everything will be affected. The cold will weaken them. We, on the other hand, can use it to our advantage.”

Hordak nodded slowly.

“And now we possess a princess.” Despara added, gesturing faintly toward the door through which Entrapta had been taken. “One that the Rebellion considered valuable.”

Shadow Weaver clicked her tongue.

“A princess without a Runestone.” She mocked. “The true power was in the magic of the Runestone, not in the creature analyzing it. It was essential to acquire that power, and you lost it.”

Her eyes drilled into Catra.

“You should be punished.”

The cold in the hangar seemed to intensify.

Catra felt Hordak’s gaze on her.

But before she could speak, Despara moved again.

“No.”

Shadow Weaver tilted her head in a questioning gesture.

“No?”

“Catra acted under my orders. If anyone should take responsibility for her…” Her voice dropped to a sharp whisper, “It’s me.”

Shadow Weaver watched her for a moment… and then smiled.

“I see.”

She didn’t say anything more.

Hordak nodded.

“Then it’s decided.”

Shadow Weaver didn’t respond, but her smile widened slightly beneath the mask. Her eyes gleamed with dark satisfaction, as if she understood something the others didn’t.

Catra felt the weight of her gaze, but didn’t react.

The fire inside her stirred, twisting with humiliation, rage… confusion.

Despara hadn’t blamed her.

She hadn’t destroyed her in front of the others, but neither had she defended her.

And somehow, that was worse.

Catra wondered if Despara’s silence was a punishment on its own. If her indifference was her way of showing that she no longer expected anything from her.

The sound of metal echoed as Hordak turned on his heel, his cape trailing behind him with a calculated motion.

“Leave.”

Catra took a second to process the order.

“What?”

Hordak didn’t even dignify her with a look.

“You’re Despara’s responsibility now. I have no interest in seeing you again unless you give me a reason to.”

Catra felt her pride twist. She clenched her fists, her claws digging into her palms. But she said nothing. She turned to leave, but before she reached the hangar doors, Desparastopped her.

“Catra. Come with me.”

It was an order. Of course it was.

But Catra didn’t question it.

She had no choice.

She forced herself to walk after her, feeling Scorpia’s gaze burn into her back until the doors closed behind them.

The Fright Zone’s corridors stretched out like an endless tunnel, an abyss of shadows and steel, lit only by the erratic flicker of monitors embedded in the walls. The cables snaked along the ceiling like veins of a mechanical creature, pulsing with cold, inhuman energy.

Catra walked behind Despara.

They didn’t speak.

Catra didn’t want to be the first to break the silence, but the weight of the unsaid was a constant pressure on her chest, as if the air grew denser with every step.

Finally, Despara stopped.

Catra barely had time to halt before bumping into her.

Despara slowly turned her head.

Her eyes shone under the dim light, empty, unfathomable.

“You lost the dagger.”

It wasn’t a question.

Catra felt a chill run down her spine. There was no way to hide it.

“Yes.”

Catra waited for a reprimand, a judgment… some reaction that would give meaning to the guilt she’d been carrying.

But Despara showed nothing.

She didn’t punish her.

She didn’t look at her with fury.

She didn’t look at her the way Adora would have.

Instead, she unsheathed her sword.

Catra tensed, her tail immediately bristling, but Despara didn’t strike.

She raised the sword calmly, as if it were a mere formality, and the air around her vibrated with dark, dense energy. It almost looked like the blade was breathing.

Catra felt her skin prickle as shadows slid from the edge, twisting and condensing into a new shape.

She recognized it immediately.

A dagger. The same one she had lost.

It emerged from the black mist, floating with an unnatural glow, as if the darkness itself were exhaling it. When the magic finished shaping it, Despara held it between her fingers and twirled it with cold indifference.

“It doesn’t matter.”

Catra blinked.

It didn’t matter?

Everything she'd been carrying with her up until now, the anxiety… didn't mean anything?

Before she could process it, Despara threw the dagger at her without looking.

Catra caught it by reflex.

The weight was the same.

Cold and sharp as a needle.

A fragment of shadow ripped from the sword. A reflection without essence.

Something that could exist or disappear in an instant.

"It's just a vessel to contain runic magic, an echo of the sword's magic. If it's not used, it disappears." She continued, spinning her sword with the same indifference she'd used to create the dagger. "Just a tool. If it's destroyed, another can be made. If it's lost, it's replaced."

Catra looked at the dagger in her hand.

"I thought it was important," she whispered without thinking.

Despara looked at her, her expression unshakable.

"It was. Until it stopped being so."

For a moment, the flickering light in the corridor made the shadows on Despara's face seem deeper, sharper.

"All tools are like this in the Horde, Catra. "They're replaceable."

Catra felt a spasm in her chest.

The dagger in her hand suddenly felt lighter. More fragile.

Catra didn't need it spelled out.

She knew Despara wasn't just talking about the dagger.

If Catra didn't prove her worth, she would vanish in a wisp of smoke just like that dagger.

Catra gripped the hilt tightly, feeling the vibration of dark magic within it.

If she let go now, the dagger would disappear.

As if it had never existed.

As if she had never existed.

But Despara kept speaking.

"Shadow Weaver and Hordak think the same way." Her voice held no emotion. "They only see soldiers, weapons, resources. Lose your purpose, and they'll discard you."

Catra felt a lump in her throat.

She already knew that.

She had always known.

The Horde didn't allow weakness.

But hearing it from Despara… hearing it from Adora, even though she wasn't Adora anymore…it hurt more than she was willing to admit.

But then, Despara did something unexpected.

She held her gaze.

And then, she closed the distance between them.

Catra didn't have time to react before Despara raised a hand and, with an unsettling gentleness, stroked her cheek.

The contact was light, but Catra's skin immediately prickled.

It wasn't a blow.

It wasn't a punishment.

It wasn't a warning.

It was… something else.

Something Despara never did.

Catra didn't know whether to pull away or stay still.

And then Despara spoke.

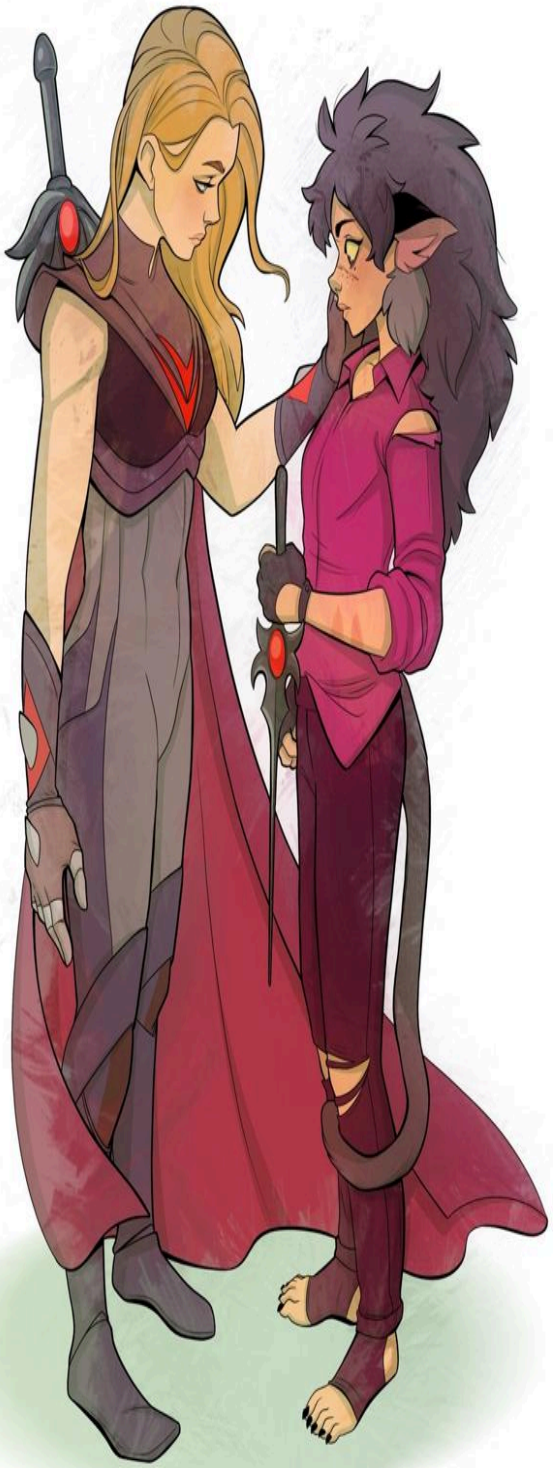
But this time, it wasn't the voice of a leader speaking to her soldier.

It was something softer.

"But I don't want to get rid of you, Catra."

Despara's fingers slid slowly off her cheek, leaving behind a trail of cold on her skin.

"You have to prove that you're worth the trust I'm giving you."



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The moment broke, and with it, any doubt Catra might have had about the true meaning of those words.

It wasn’t affection.

It was an offer to atone, one that Despara could take away at any moment.

Despara turned and continued on her way, cutting off any possibility of a reply.

For a moment, Catra considered whether to follow her, as if doing so would mean accepting the offer that had just been presented to her.

Finally, she relented and walked in silence behind Despara.

Like the good subordinate she was.

————————————THE END————————————

Chapter End Notes

> 🖤 It's been quite a while since we last updated this little story! Writing isn’t exactly our forte, but we still hope you’ve enjoyed this fragment of our Despara AU. 🖤

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!